

THE CALENDAR CONFLICT

Recommendation (direct): Prioritize the investor meeting if the outcome materially affects funding or runway; ask the partner to either move the meeting by 30–60 minutes or send a trusted delegate to represent you. If the investor meeting is flexible, shift it by 15–30 minutes. Below I give a short action plan you can execute in the next 30–90 minutes, ready-to-send communication drafts for email/Slack/phone, and the logic I used to reach this plan.

Action plan (step-by-step, with timeline)

- 0–10 minutes — Triage: confirm which meeting has immovable attendees, which is flexible, and whether a delegate is acceptable for either. Quick Slack/DM or a 1–2 sentence phone call is best.
- 10–20 minutes — Execute the fastest fix: call or send the highest-priority stakeholder a short message asking whether a 15–30 minute shift or a delegate is possible. Use the appropriate draft below.
- 20–40 minutes — If a reschedule is agreed, update the calendar and send confirmation. If not, confirm the delegate and send a briefing pack to the delegate.
- 40–90 minutes — Prep for the meeting you will attend (one-page brief + 3 key asks) and send the delegate a 10–15 minute prep call if they are representing you.

Decision criteria (how I prioritized) Score each meeting across:

- Impact: financial/strategic consequence (high = investors)
- Flexibility: possible to move without harm
- Attendee criticality: are specific people required?
- Prep already invested: time you've spent preparing
- Visibility/precedent: e.g., investor no-shows risk reputation more than partner reschedules

Use the weighted score (Impact > Attendee criticality > Flexibility). If investors have equal or higher impact, prioritize them. If the partner is uniquely time-sensitive (e.g., product release coordination with a hard deadline), consider alternatives.

Recommended default outcome

- If investor = higher impact: attend investor, request partner to move or send delegate.
- If partner = higher impact (rare): attend partner, ask investor for a short shift or have a senior colleague take the investor call.
- If both absolutely immovable and high-impact: split — attend first 20–30 minutes of one, send delegate to the other, and schedule immediate follow-ups.

Communication drafts Use the tone: concise, respectful, solution-focused. Below are templates you can copy-paste and adjust.

A. Short Slack/DM (use immediately to triage)

- To partner (DM/Slack): Hi [Name], quick scheduling conflict—an investor meeting overlapped with our slot at [time]. Would you be open to moving by 30 minutes, or would you prefer I send [colleague] to represent us? I can accommodate either. Appreciate a quick call/text if easier.
- To the investor (DM/Slack): Hi [Name], quick note—I've got a conflicting high-priority meeting at [time]. Is there any flexibility to start 15–30 minutes later, or would you prefer we keep the time and I join promptly at [time]? Either works; let me know.

B. Email to request reschedule (partner)

Subject: Small timing conflict for today — request to move our meeting

Hi [Partner Name],

I'm looking forward to our meeting at [scheduled time]. A conflicting high-priority meeting with investors has just come up. Could we please shift our meeting by 30 minutes to [new time option] or by 60 minutes to [alternate option]? If that doesn't work, I can send [colleague name], who's fully briefed and can represent us. Apologies for the short notice—happy to be flexible to make this work.

Best,

[You]

C. Email to request reschedule (investor)

Subject: Quick timing question about our meeting today

Hi [Investor Name],

I very much value your time and I'm looking forward to our discussion at [time]. I have a last-minute scheduling overlap with a critical partner conversation. Is there any chance we could start 15–30 minutes later (proposed: [new time])? If not, I'll be there at the scheduled time—just wanted to check.

Thank you for understanding.

Best regards,

[You]

D. Phone script (if it's urgent / and you can call)

- For the party you want to move: "Hi [Name], sorry to interrupt — I have a last-minute overlap with another high-priority meeting. Would you have 15–30 minutes flexibility to shift our meeting? If not, I can send [a colleague] to represent me. Which would you prefer?"

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E. Delegate briefing note (sent to the colleague who will attend)

Subject: Briefing for meeting with [Partner/Investor] at [time]

Hi [Colleague],

Thanks for covering the [partner/investor] meeting. Key points:

- Objective: [1–2 sentence goal: e.g., secure a term sheet conversation, confirm integration timeline, etc.]
- Top 3 messages to deliver: [Message 1] [Message 2] [Message 3]
- Asks to make: [exact ask and acceptable alternatives]
- Must not commit to: [list anything they must not promise]
- Attachments: [one-pager, deck, data] Please aim to capture decisions and outstanding questions in the meeting notes and ping me immediately after. I'm available for a 10-minute prep call at [time]. Appreciate it — you'll be fully backed.

F. Calendar update note (if you reschedule) Update the invite with this short description: Quick reschedule due to last-minute conflict — new time [new time]. If this causes an issue, reply and we'll find a slot that works.

If you cannot move either meeting: split/overlap plan

- Option A (best when both parties accept partial attendance): Attend the first 25 minutes of Meeting A (start on time), then switch, and join Meeting B for their final 25 minutes. Before switching, say: "I need to hop to another high-priority call—[colleague] will continue in my stead and handle Q&A. I'll rejoin at [time]."
- Option B (best when both require decision-makers): Appoint senior, pre-briefed delegates to both meetings and schedule 15-minute follow-ups back-to-back with each party.

Risk analysis and mitigations

- Risk: Offending a stakeholder by asking to move. Mitigation: Offer options (move or delegate), give a reason (brief, truthful), propose concrete new times, and emphasize flexibility.
- Risk: Delegate underperforms. Mitigation: Send concise briefing, 10-minute prep, and explicitly list "must not commit" and "asks."
- Risk: Reputation cost with investors. Mitigation: If investor is sensitive, either attend them or ask investor which option they prefer and be explicit about stakes.

How I made this recommendation (logic and why)

- Central principle: Protect highest-impact outcomes. A meeting's strategic and financial consequences (funding, contract signature, legal/launch deadlines) should guide priority.
- Practical constraints: People's availability, the ability to delegate without losing progress, and the visibility/cost of a no-show.
- Negotiation strategy: People tolerate short reschedule requests if you propose a concrete alternative and show respect for their time. Always give a specific new time and the option to decline.
- Communication tone: Brief, apologetic but confident, and solution-focused. This signals professionalism and reduces friction.
- Delegation rules I used: only delegate if the representative is empowered on the core asks; provide a crisp brief and "do not commit" guardrails.

Checklist to execute now:

1. Decide which meeting you will attend (investor / partner / split). If you want, tell me which and I'll tailor drafts further.
2. Send the appropriate short DM or email from the templates above to the party you want moved or to the one you want to confirm.
3. If sending a delegate, pick the colleague, send the delegate briefing note, and schedule a 10–15 minute prep call immediately.
4. Update calendar invites and confirm with all attendees.